

NAVIGATING CHINA AI MODELS

New frontier from Kimi K3; from cost efficiency, intelligence to pricing power of Chinese models

Navigating China Internet / AI models

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**From cost efficiency (DeepSeek), rise in model intelligence (GLM) to new frontier/pricing power at Kimi K3**

On July 17, the Kimi K3 open-weight model was released with 2.8 trillion parameters, and has set a new frontier in coding and certain agentic capabilities globally, as per Arena.ai coding rank and Artificial Analysis Intelligence score ([Exhibit 1](#)). Accordingly, we note K3's pricing was set at a new high amongst Chinese models, US\$2.3 per 1M tokens (blended) vs. Qwen3.7 Max of US\$1.4/Zhipu's GLM5.2 of US\$0.9/MiniMax's M3 of US\$0.22/DeepSeek's V4 Pro of US\$0.18, being still below global SOTA models, [Exhibit 3](#).

As highlighted in our recent [China LLM primer](#), we believe China's AI open-source/open-weight models are reaching a critical point of intelligence performance for global proliferation. Amongst signposts into 2H 2026, we have anticipated that competition could intensify in the high-end coding segment via coding data flywheel and scaling (to larger models, up to 2-5 trillions parameter sizes). We believe the share price reaction of Knowledge Atlas/Zhipu (where we recently [initiated at Neutral](#), -28% on July 17) and MiniMax (Buy-rated, -16% on July 17) have been due to concerns around Chinese AI model competition and who the potential long-term winners will be, given the competitive landscape/sustainability of model company leadership remains highly dynamic.

We continue to note that independent AI model companies stand out in our Competitive Positioning framework. We also note positive read from Chinese President Xi's [comments](#) at the opening ceremony of World Artificial Intelligence Conference (WAIC) in Shanghai held today, drawing parallels of AI's societal impact to the invention of electricity and steam engines, and in offering China's technology infrastructure to developing nations with its continued open approach, yet cautioned on the need for human oversight/controls and risk mitigation.

What to watch out for from here? As highlighted in our [LLM primer](#):

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- **Harness/agent applications:** We expect China AI model companies to increasingly focus on positioning their harness/agent applications as key entry points, especially in coding (e.g. Zhipu's ZCode, Tencent's Workbuddy, and Alibaba's Qoder which are aggregate platforms that support the full suite of AI models) as model companies attempt to close the loop in capturing more real-life coding and agent data for scaling. Co-work and industry expert agent products could be the next priorities.
- **Multiple large parameter high-end coding model launches and potentially stricter access to the most advanced Chinese AI models outside of China:** After Kimi K3 launch, we anticipate for further new Chinese AI model launches over 2H26 (Zhipu GLM, Alibaba Qwen, MiniMax M3 Pro and more) with significantly larger total parameter sizes of 2-5 trillion across Chinese AI model players. Coding/programming segment competition will remain intense. The addition of multi-modal/visual understanding will also be the next upgrades amongst Chinese AI foundation models.
- **Continued suppressed API pricing for the lower end agent-focused segment:** We expect API pricing and therefore gross margins to remain under pressure at the lower-end pricing segment (around US\$0.1-0.2 per 1M tokens) into the second half, as China's AI model players have significant cash buffers post-fund raising to subsidize competitive pricing. As a result, we see financial strength as one of the three most important metrics (alongside pricing power and cost efficiencies) in assessing a Chinese AI model company.
- **Multi-modal/video-generation models to see further ARR ramp-up from global adoption:** We expect continued healthy industry pricing and gross margins within video generation (unlike foundation text) where key players ByteDance's SeeDance (at reportedly 70% gross margins, latest US\$2bn ARR run-rate), Kuaishou's (Buy) Kling and MiniMax's (Buy) Hailuo/upcoming H3 models to enjoy healthy growth over 2H 2026 amid new functionality breakthroughs (combination of video-generation with LLM) and tight computing resources where demand significantly outpaces capacity.
- We also expect increasing domestic ASICs supply, any stricter access to China's future most frontier models for overseas markets, Western markets' policies on China models, and access to high-end computing in model training as key swing factors/risks to our China AI model token/revenue growth trajectory.

Our key ideas/stock picks

- Within Cloud & Data Centers (our top preferred sub-sector within China Internet), we continue to highlight key ideas (Alibaba, GDS, VNET, and Kingsoft Cloud) on the back of higher AI hyperscaler capex spending into 2H 2026.
- Within AI models, we highlight MiniMax on upside skewed risk-reward. Key swing factors for MiniMax to improve its overall competitive positioning will hinge on its pricing power following its recent completed fund-raising that has strengthened financial strength. We expect its H3 video generation model performance (imminent launch in a more favorable industry landscape vs. text models) and time-to-market

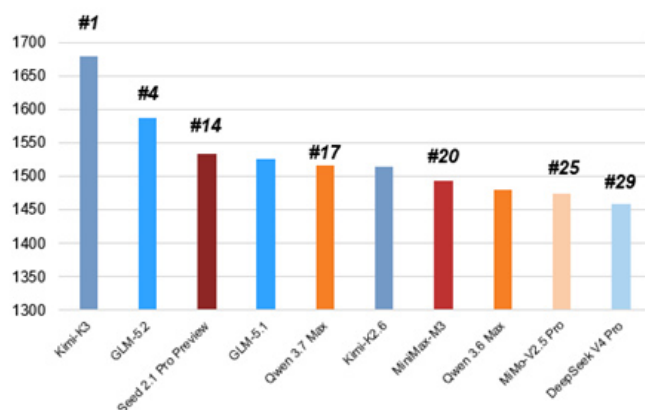
for its next M3 updates (focusing on further coding intelligence level uplift from post-training/reinforcement learning, we estimate M3 update over July-Aug, and a larger parameter size M3 Pro model later in 2H 2026) will be the next key drivers.

See also from our recent reports

- [Navigating China AI models: LLM primer: Critical point of intelligence for global proliferation](#), July 10, 2026
- [Knowledge Atlas Technology \(2513.HK\): Initiate with Neutral at US\\$110bn valuation: China's top enterprise/coding AI model](#), July 10, 2026
- [MiniMax Group \(0100.HK\): Key focuses post-share unlock; upside skew to risk-reward; Buy](#), July 10, 2026

Exhibit 1: Code Arena have updated their global ranking...

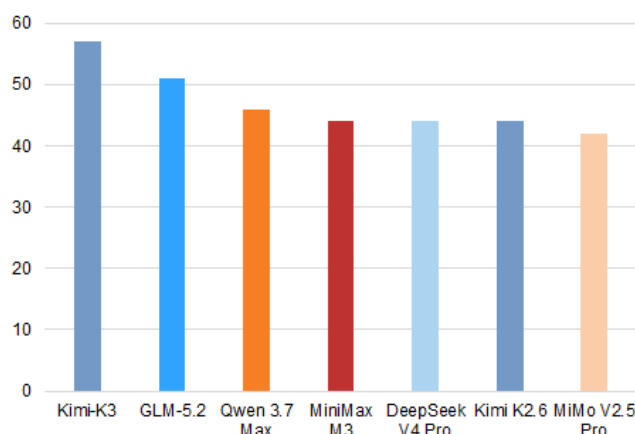
Latest score and model ranking as of July 16, 2026



Source: LMArena, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

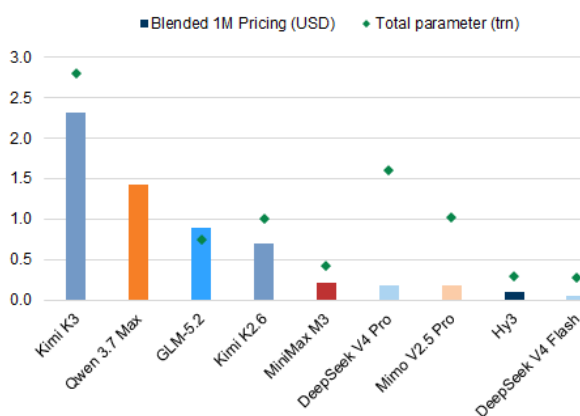
Exhibit 2: ...with Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index also reaching at/near global SOTA level

Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index



Source: Artificial Analysis, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

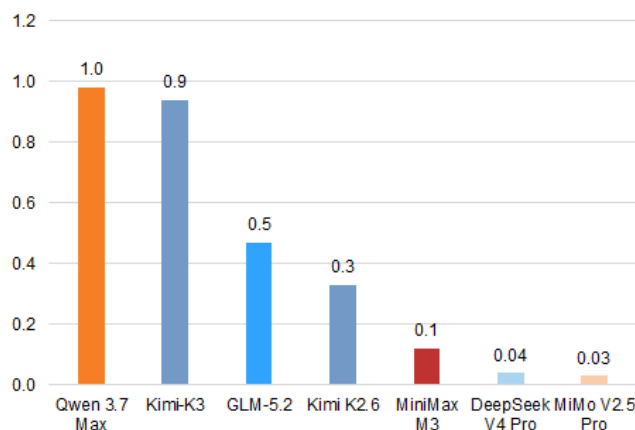
Exhibit 3: Kimi K3 raised blended API pricing on rising model intelligence and parameter size



Source: Artificial Analysis, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

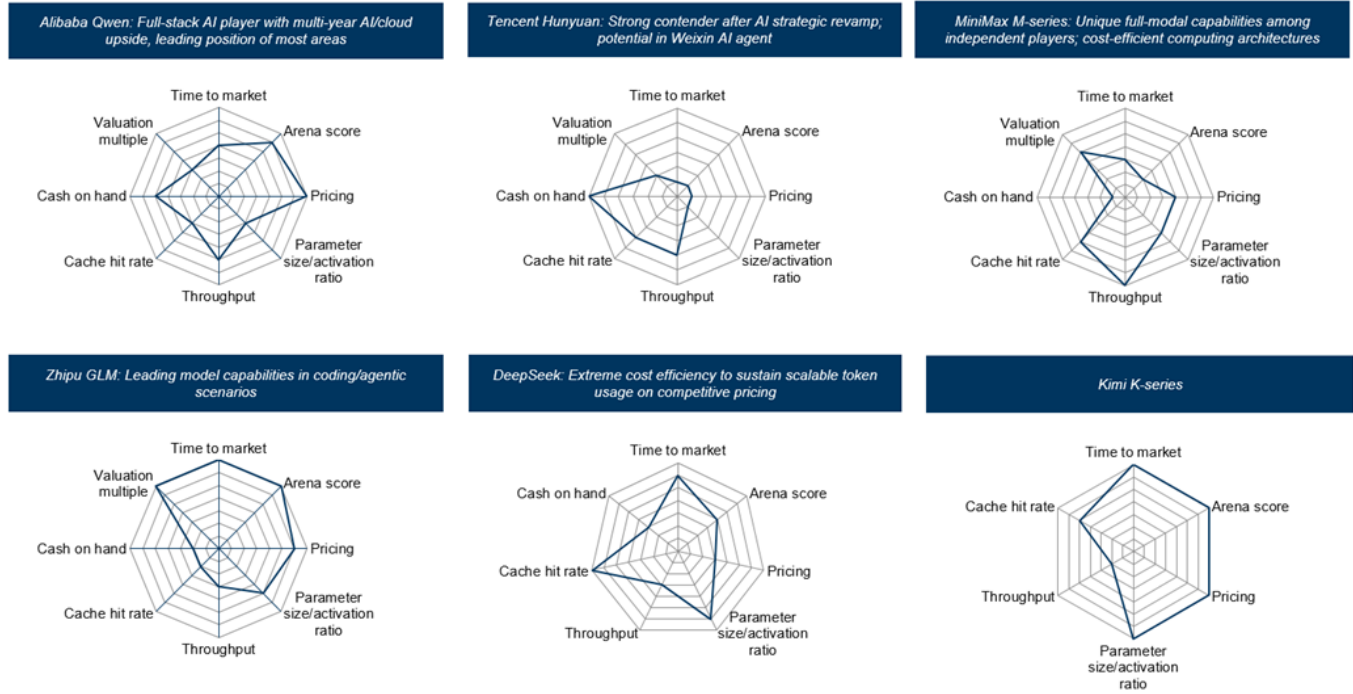
Exhibit 4: Total cost to complete AA Intelligence benchmark test rises 3X, same scale with API pricing hike

Cost per task (US\$)



Source: Artificial Analysis, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 5: Our competitive positioning analysis for key LLM labs/models



N/A for private companies valuation multiple

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 6: Competitive positioning framework for AI model players

Key themes	Chinese models reaching critical stage of intelligence for wide adoption across agentic tasks/specific coding scenarios			Fragmentation between China AI models but strong to get stronger; pricing power to come from frontier performance/multi-modal			Agentic AI driving higher demand for value-for-money models/SLMs		Access to computing, where balance sheet and inference efficiency are key		
Drivers of corporate performance	Competitive positioning										
CP category	Pricing Power			Cost advantage				Financial strength			
CP metrics	Time to market	Arena score	Pricing	Token volume	Throughput /Cache hit rate	Parameter size/ activation ratio	Inference GPM	Cash on hand	Net cash as % of asset	Valuation multiples	

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Price Target Risks and Methodology - MiniMax Group

We are Buy rated on MiniMax with a 12-month target price of HK\$860. Our valuation is based on DCF valuation, with 12% WACC and 2% terminal growth rate.

Key risks: Weaker-than-expected model performance amid the competition in the global foundation model industry; Slower-than-expected path to profit visibility; Weaker-than-expected commercialization capability; risks around IP/content generation; cash burn/self-funding capability; risks around geopolitics under an intensified tech race between the US and China.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Knowledge Atlas Technology

We are Neutral rated on Knowledge Atlas with a 12-month target price of HK\$1,880. Our valuation is based on DCF valuation, with 12% WACC and 2% terminal growth rate (consistent with our coverage).

Key risks: **(+)** Stronger-than-expected model intelligence, **(+)** Faster-than-expected path to profit visibility, **(+)** Additional non-inference take rate revenue streams, **(+)** Stronger-than-expected commercialization capability, **(-)** Competition in global foundation model industry, **(-)** Limited near-term profit visibility due to high R&D expenses, **(-)** Cash burn/self-funding capability, **(-)** Risk around geopolitics under an intensified tech race between the US and China.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Tencent Holdings

Valuation methodology: We are Buy rated on Tencent (0700.HK), with a 12-m SOTP-based TP of **HK\$700**.

Key risks: More intense industry competition in performance-based advertising, unexpected delays in game launches/Banhao approvals, moderated growth in FinTech and Cloud businesses, slower-than-expected AI development progress, reinvestment risk.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Alibaba Group

Valuation methodology: We are Buy rated on BABA/9988.HK, with SOTP-based 12-month target prices of US\$186/HK\$180 per ADS/share (FY27E-based).

Key risks: (1) Lower-than-expected GMV growth due to macro/competition; (2) Slower-than-expected monetization in China retail; (3) Weaker-than-expected execution in key strategic investments; and (4) Cloud revenue growth deceleration.

Disclosure Appendix

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We, Ronald Keung, CFA, Allen Chang, Lincoln Kong, CFA, Timothy Zhao, Damian Xie, Iris Xiao, Steve Qiu, Eunice Liu and Luqing Zhou, hereby certify that all of the views expressed in this report accurately reflect our personal views about the subject company or companies and its or their securities. We also certify that no part of our compensation was, is or will be, directly or indirectly, related to the specific recommendations or views expressed in this report.

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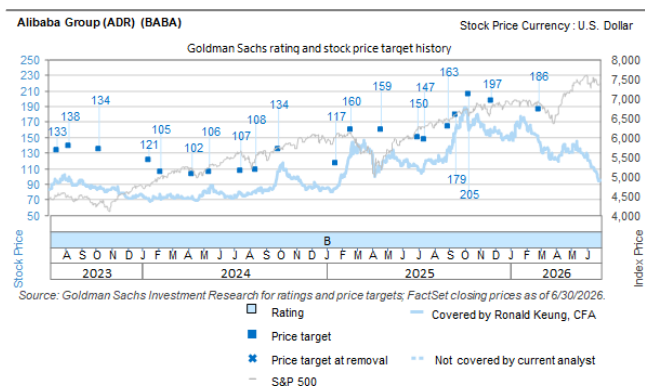
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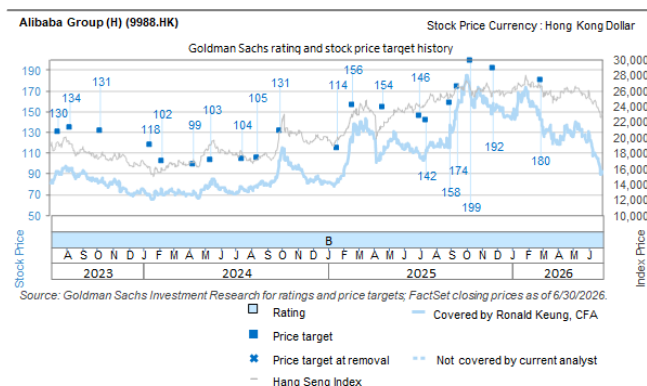
	Rating Distribution				Investment Banking Relationships		
	Buy	Hold	Sell		Buy	Hold	Sell
Global	50%	34%	16%		65%	59%	43%

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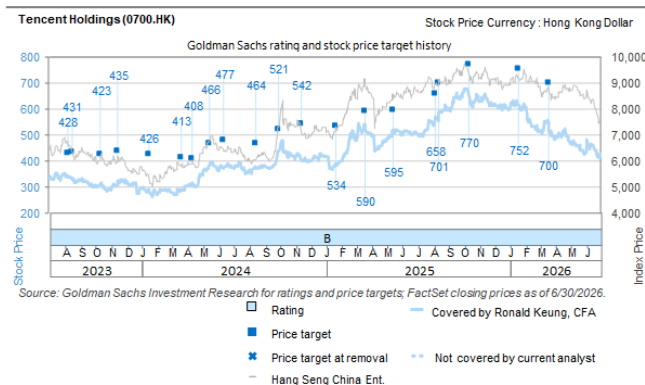
Price target and rating history chart(s)



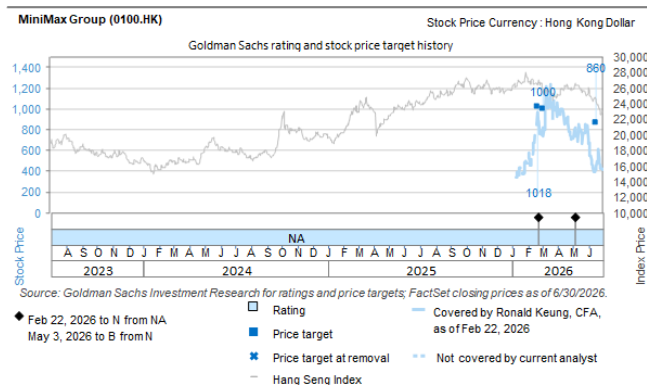
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Target price history table(s)

Alibaba Group (ADR) (BABA)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
27-Feb-26	186.00	144.11
25-Nov-25	197.00	157.01
12-Oct-25	205.00	159.01
16-Sep-25	179.00	162.21

Tencent Holdings (0700.HK)

Date of report	Target price (HK\$)	Closing price (HK\$)
18-Mar-26	700.00	550.50
18-Jan-26	752.00	617.50
12-Oct-25	770.00	651.50
13-Aug-25	701.00	586.00

Alibaba Group (ADR) (BABA)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
31-Aug-25	163.00	135.00
15-Jul-25	147.00	116.97
02-Jul-25	150.00	110.71
21-Apr-25	159.00	110.15
20-Feb-25	160.00	135.97
20-Jan-25	117.00	85.12
29-Sep-24	134.00	107.33
15-Aug-24	108.00	79.54
16-Jul-24	107.00	78.38
15-May-24	106.00	80.99
11-Apr-24	102.00	74.85
07-Feb-24	105.00	73.64
15-Jan-24	121.00	71.84
09-Oct-23	134.00	84.85
10-Aug-23	138.00	99.21

Tencent Holdings (0700.HK)

Date of report	Target price (HK\$)	Closing price (HK\$)
05-Aug-25	658.00	559.00
14-May-25	595.00	521.00
19-Mar-25	590.00	540.00
20-Jan-25	534.00	389.80
13-Nov-24	542.00	403.80
29-Sep-24	521.00	437.80
14-Aug-24	464.00	373.80
12-Jun-24	477.00	370.80
15-May-24	466.00	381.80
11-Apr-24	408.00	315.00
20-Mar-24	413.00	288.80
15-Jan-24	426.00	289.40
15-Nov-23	435.00	322.60
11-Oct-23	423.00	311.00
16-Aug-23	431.00	328.80
07-Aug-23	428.00	341.20

Knowledge Atlas Technology (2513.HK)

Date of report	Target price (HK\$)	Closing price (HK\$)
09-Jul-26	1,880.00	2,032.00

Alibaba Group (H) (9988.HK)

Date of report	Target price (HK\$)	Closing price (HK\$)
27-Feb-26	180.00	142.90
25-Nov-25	192.00	157.80
12-Oct-25	199.00	165.40
16-Sep-25	174.00	153.50
31-Aug-25	158.00	115.70
15-Jul-25	142.00	113.50
02-Jul-25	146.00	109.40
21-Apr-25	154.00	108.70
20-Feb-25	156.00	120.90
20-Jan-25	114.00	84.55
29-Sep-24	131.00	102.50
15-Aug-24	105.00	76.40
16-Jul-24	104.00	75.50
15-May-24	103.00	82.65
11-Apr-24	99.00	74.20
07-Feb-24	102.00	74.90
15-Jan-24	118.00	70.00
09-Oct-23	131.00	82.10
10-Aug-23	134.00	94.30

MiniMax Group (0100.HK)

Date of report	Target price (HK\$)	Closing price (HK\$)
16-Jun-26	860.00	416.60
03-Mar-26	1,000.00	821.00
22-Feb-26	1,018.00	970.00

Price targets shown in table(s) are unadjusted for corporate actions.

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